FORWARD SUPPORT

A FAMILY'S GUIDE

Moving to Catherine House.

For families, loved ones, and anyone wondering what life looks like for the people who live with us. A gentle walkthrough of who we are, how a placement with us works, and what you can expect.

"Care and support you can believe in."

Version 2.0 · April 2026

Forward Support Care Ltd
Catherine House, Taunton
01823 630750

A NOTE FROM LAURA

Hello. I'm Laura.

Finding the right home for someone you love is not an easy thing to do. There is a lot to take in, a lot of paperwork, and a lot of questions. This guide is written to try to answer most of them, honestly and without jargon.

I'm Laura Luxon, the Registered Manager at Catherine House. I've been with this home for many years, first as Home Manager and, since June 2024, as Registered Manager under Forward Support Care Ltd. I'm here every day. If you want to know what Catherine House is really like, the fastest way to find out is to come and see, and to ask me anything you want to ask.

What follows is a guide. It explains who we are, how a placement with us works, what a typical day looks like, and what we ask of families. If anything in it doesn't answer what you need to know, please phone me on **01823 630750**, or email **info@forwardsupport.co.uk**. There is no such thing as a silly or early question.

> **Who this guide is for**
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> This guide is for families, partners, siblings, friends, and loved ones of adults with learning disabilities who are considering Catherine House as a home. It is also for anyone supporting them to make that decision. Social workers and commissioners have a separate Placement Information Pack available on request.

ABOUT CATHERINE HOUSE

A small home where people are known by name.

Catherine House is a five-bed residential care home on Hamilton Road, in the centre of Taunton. It's the kind of home that feels like a home, because it is one.

Who we look after

Everyone who lives with us is an adult with a learning disability. Some of our residents also have autism, sensory needs, or communication differences. Most have lived with us for years. We don't take short-term placements, and we don't run other homes. Catherine House is what we do, and we pour everything into getting it right.

Why a small home matters

There's a reason we have five bedrooms and not twenty-five. In a small home, staff know residents as individuals, not as rooms. They know what makes them laugh, what they watch on a Sunday, what foods they hate, what time they wake up, who they ring on their birthday. That kind of knowing only happens when the numbers are small.

It also matters for family. You don't have to explain yourself every time you call. You'll speak to someone who knows your son, your daughter, your brother, your friend. By name. Every time.

The team who'll be there

Our staff team is small and stable, and we work hard to keep it that way. High staff turnover is one of the things that hurts care homes most, so we protect against it. Our staff are paid above the minimum wage, they have an Employee Assistance Programme, and they get regular supervision and training. Because when staff are looked after, they stay. And when they stay, they know the people they care for better.

LIFE AT CATHERINE HOUSE

Routine, choice, and the ordinary stuff of life.

The best care homes feel ordinary. Nothing hurried, nothing clinical, just a place where people live their lives.

A typical day

There's no set timetable that everyone follows. Each person has their own rhythm, built around what they like and what works for them. Some people are early risers, others take their time. Some have a structured day with work, activities, or college. Others prefer gentler days at home. Every day includes meals together, time out in the community where wanted, and space to be quiet if that's needed too.

Activities and the community

Taunton has a lot to offer, and we try to use it. Local cafes, the park, shopping, swimming, cinema, bus rides, the seaside when the weather's right. We also have activities at home, from baking to crafts to evenings in with a film. Nothing is obligatory. Everything is offered, and people choose.

Food

Meals are cooked in the home, freshly, with residents involved where they want to be. Menus are planned weekly with input from the people who'll be eating. We work around medical requirements, personal preferences, and cultural or religious needs.

Bedrooms

Each resident has their own bedroom. We encourage people to personalise their space with photos, favourite things, preferred bedding. This is their home. Family can bring in items to make the room feel more familiar, especially during the first few weeks after moving in.

Health and wellbeing

We manage medications, GP appointments, dental and eye checks, specialist consultants, and any health needs that come up. We liaise closely with families and health professionals. If something is worrying us, or changing, you'll hear about it.

FAMILY INVOLVEMENT

You are welcome here, and you matter.

Some families are close to their loved one every week. Others live a long way away and visit a few times a year. Some stay involved by phone and photo. All of these are fine. What matters is that you know what's going on and that you're not left out.

Visiting

Visits are welcome. We prefer a quick phone call in advance so we can make sure your family member is home and settled, but we don't set rigid visiting hours. This is their home, and visitors are part of their life.

Staying in touch

Phone calls, video calls, text, letters, we support whatever works. If your loved one has communication needs that make these harder, we'll work with you to find approaches that help. Photos and short updates are regular, especially in the first few months after a move-in when families want reassurance that the transition is going well.

Care planning

We write a care and support plan for each person when they move in, and we review it regularly. You're welcome to be part of that conversation, and in most cases we actively want you to be. You know things about your loved one that no one else does, and that knowledge is valuable.

Celebrations and milestones

Birthdays, Christmas, Easter, other days that matter to the individual and the family. We mark these. We're happy to plan around family visits, outings, or particular traditions.

When things are difficult

Not every day will be smooth. There will sometimes be moments of worry, illness, behaviour that seems out of character, or decisions that are hard to make. We'll be honest with you about what's happening and what we're doing. We'll also ask for your help when we need it, because we know families usually have the longest perspective.

HOW A PLACEMENT WORKS

What happens, from first call to moving day.

The path to moving in is different for every family, depending on how care is funded and what support you already have in place. Here are the two most common routes.

Route 1: Most common, through a local authority

For most of our residents, the placement is funded by a local authority (such as Somerset Council) or by the NHS. In this case, a social worker is usually the first person to contact us, often acting for your family.

1

Referral from the social worker

A social worker or commissioner contacts us with information about the individual and the support they need.

2

Initial conversation

Laura talks it through with the social worker, reviews assessments and care plans, and says honestly whether we think we could be the right home.

3

Visit and meet

We invite the individual and the family to visit Catherine House. More than once, if helpful. This is as much for you as for us.

4

Formal assessment and funding panel

The local authority arranges its formal assessment and funding decision. We support this by providing our written response.

5

Transition planning

Once the placement is agreed, we plan a transition at the right pace for your loved one. Sometimes that's a single move-in day. Sometimes it's several visits over a few weeks.

6

Moving day

Personal belongings, bedroom set up, familiar things in place. Family welcome for as long as feels right.

Route 2: Direct enquiry from family

If you're a family member reaching out to us directly, perhaps because you're looking at care options and Catherine House has come up, we welcome that. Call us or email us, have an informal conversation, visit if you'd like. If a placement feels like it might be right, we'll help you understand what happens next, including how to get a social worker involved or how a private placement would work.

A note on fees

Fees depend on the level of support someone needs. There's no standard price. If the placement is local-authority funded, fees are agreed directly with the authority and you're usually not involved in that side of things. If the placement is private, we'll talk it through with you honestly and explain exactly what's included. Either way, the details can be discussed with Laura directly.

COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions families most often ask.

How will I know they're settling in?

During the first few weeks we'll be in regular contact, usually by phone and with photos or short updates. You'll know how the first meal went, how the first night went, how they're getting on with the other residents. If something worries us, we'll tell you straight away.

Can they still see the same GP, dentist, consultant?

Where possible, yes. If your loved one has a GP they've been with a long time, we'll keep that relationship if the practice allows it. Otherwise we'll register them with a local GP and share the handover properly. Specialist appointments continue as normal and we'll get them there and support them.

What if they don't like it?

The first few weeks after moving into any new home are an adjustment. We plan slow transitions where we can, we encourage lots of familiar things in the bedroom, and we spend extra time alongside the person until they find their feet. If, after a genuine settling-in period, it really isn't working, we'll be honest with you and work together on what's best.

What happens if I'm worried about something?

Tell us. Directly, straight away. The best way is to phone Laura on 01823 630750. No concern is too small. Our complaints policy is available on request and we'll always follow it openly if that's the right route, but most things are resolved with a conversation.

What does CQC 'Good' actually mean?

The Care Quality Commission is the independent regulator for care services in England. They visit, inspect, and rate every registered care home. Catherine House was rated Good at its last full inspection. You can look us up at cqc.org.uk and read the full report. In June 2024, the company running the home changed from a sole trader to a limited company (Forward Support Care Ltd), so our next inspection under the new registration is pending. The same team, the same home, the same standards.

What if I live a long way away?

Many families do. We support distance relationships with regular phone calls, photos, video calls, and longer in-person visits when you can make the trip. We can help organise accommodation near Taunton for longer visits.

What if I want to just ask a question, not make an enquiry?

Please do. You can call us and say "I'm not ready to enquire, I just have a question". That's welcome and normal.

GET IN TOUCH

Come and see us.

The fastest way to know if Catherine House is the right home is to come and see it, and to meet the people who'd be looking after your loved one. Call, write, or just show up (though a call ahead helps).

CALL US

Laura Luxon

Registered Manager. First point of contact for any family enquiry, visit, or conversation.

01823 630750

info@forwardsupport.co.uk

VISIT US

Catherine House

Please phone ahead so we can make sure your loved one (if they already live here) is settled, or so Laura is available to meet you.

131 Hamilton Road

Taunton, Somerset

TA1 2EP

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